



▲ INDUS VALLEY CIVILIZATION

At its peak, the Indus Valley Civilization stretched from northeast Afghanistan, through Pakistan, and into northwest India. The Indus people developed extensive trade networks across the region. They recorded their transactions on engraved seals, like the one pictured above.

MAJOR EMPIRES

322–185 BCE

Founded by Chandragupta Maurya, the Mauryan Empire grows to become India's largest kingdom, covering nearly all of the Indian subcontinent.

c. 135 BCE–c. 225 CE

The Kushans of Central Asia conquer modern-day Afghanistan and northwest India. Their empire reaches its greatest extent under Kanishka I in the 2nd century CE.

c. 275–c. 897 CE

The Pallava Empire, known for its art and architecture, controls much of south India from its capital at Kanchipuram, Tamil Nadu.

320–c. 550 CE

The reign of the Gupta Empire is a golden age for India. The empire is at peace and grows wealthy from trade. The arts and culture flourish.



GUPTA
PERIOD COIN

Ancient India

The earliest civilization on the Indian subcontinent first spread along the Indus River around 2500 BCE. For the next 5,000 years, a series of empires rose and fell in the region, and two of today's major world religions, Hinduism and Buddhism, first appeared on the subcontinent.

The Indus Valley Civilization suddenly declined after 1800 BCE, and nomadic tribes swept in from Central Asia to conquer much of northern India. For the next 1,500 years, the region was divided. During this period the Vedas—sacred texts of Hinduism—were composed. In 326 BCE, the armies of Alexander the Great (see p.27) invaded northern India. This inspired Chandragupta, ruler of the powerful Magadha kingdom, to rise up. He drove out Alexander's successors and in 322 BCE established the Mauryan Empire. The Mauryans expanded to the south, uniting India for the first time.



ASHOKA'S PILLARS ▲

Emperor Ashoka had stone pillars built across his empire, which were carved with inscriptions instructing people how to live a Buddhist life. A pillar at Sarnath, Uttar Pradesh, was topped with a sculpture of four back-to-back lions (above), which in 1950 became India's official emblem.

Chandragupta's grandson, Emperor Ashoka, was one of India's greatest rulers. Following a violent and bloody war, he converted to Buddhism and its influence quickly spread. The Maurya Empire declined after Ashoka's death in c. 231 BCE, and a number of smaller kingdoms came to power. From 320 CE, most of north and central India came under the rule of the Gupta Empire, which promoted Hinduism but was tolerant of other religions.

